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WOMEN'S PLACE IN DIPLOMACY THROUGH THE FRENCH DIPLOMATIC CORRESPONDENCES IN THE EARLY SEVENTEENTH CENTURY

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In the early seventeenth century, while women could occasionally be requested to take part, or even to lead, some diplomatic negotiations, they seemed to be excluded from the daily practice of French diplomacy. Official diplomatic offices were indeed reserved for men – only men could be appointed as ambassadors, residents, agents or even as official informants. No official diplomatic, or even political, charge could be assigned to a woman. Women were, however, omnipresent at the court: they were the wives of ambassadors, ministers, princes or kings and participated as such to the court life. The European sociability relied on them. Moreover, if women appeared to have been mostly considered as untrustworthy for political matters, some of them could reach the head of the state, like Marie de Medici¹ (1575-1642), the French regent between 1610 and 1617,² or Isabella Clara Eugenia (1566-1633), co-sovereign (1598-1621) then governess of the Spanish Netherlands (1621-1633).³ This questions the real position of women, especially of female sovereigns, in the French diplomatic practice.

¹ French historiography has for a long time been quite critical of Marie de Medici and took up various pamphlets from her opponents which represented her as a queen of low intelligence and high susceptibility. The biography from Jean-François Dubost redefines her personality and gives her back a political place as ruler of the kingdom in the 1610s. See Jean-François Dubost: *Marie de Médicis: la reine dévoilée*. Paris: Payot, 2009.

² Marie de Medici's regency ended in 1614 when the majority of the king is proclaimed. The young king decided however to nominate his mother as head of the Council. She assumed government until April 1617.

³ When Archduke Albert died in July 1621, the Infanta Isabella lost her status of co-sovereign and governed in the name of the Spanish King until her death in 1633. Unfortunately, the Low Countries have not aroused much interest from historians, although recent international works begin to fill the gap. See Luc Duerloo: *Dynasty and Piety: Archduke Albert (1598–1621) and Habsburg political culture in an age of religious wars*. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012; Cordula van Wyhe (ed): *Isabel Clara Eugenia: female sovereignty in the Courts of Madrid and Bruxelles*. Madrid/London: Centro de Estudios Europea Hispanica / Paul Holberton publishing, 2011.

As the major communication tool of early modern diplomacy, correspondence appears to offer a solid way to overcome this seeming diplomatic inactivity of women

. The permanent diplomatic agent, as a central member of the diplomatic system, had to relate precisely each event at a foreign court, so that the secretary of state, and the monarch could fully understand the foreign situation and adapt to it the French foreign policy. Letters were, for them, the only way to transmit this information and in return receive orders and advice. Thus, letters stand as reports whose regularity allows a continuous epistolary flow. Diplomatic work was governed by the frequency of these letters and remained within the male preserve. Writings produced by an embassy or a residency (letters, reports, even attachments like copies of letters or documents), and on which we depend to study women were composed by men. This male domination of the writing process undoubtedly skews our understanding of the diplomatic practice; and the objectivity of their narrative and analyses has to be questioned. The sources cannot reflect the reality of early modern diplomacy but only a male-constructed reality which merges the conception of the agents and an adapted representation of their practice in order to please their sovereign. As women had no place in the official diplomatic structure, nor in the writing process, they would appear to be almost excluded from any representation of diplomatic life. In fact, a hundred and seventeen letters only, within a corpus of more than 1500⁴, mention women, yet they do reveal various interaction levels within diplomatic life (the ambassador's wife, another diplomat's wife, the foreign sovereign's wife, their own queen).

THE AMBASSADOR'S WIFE AS PART OF THE DOMESTIC LIFE

At the beginning of the seventeenth century, the ambassador's wife had no official status in French diplomacy, nor were they mentioned in their husband's official instructions. They were not even constrained to follow their husbands abroad. Unlike their men, whose representative duties required to stay continuously at an assigned foreign court, the wives could move, almost, as often as they wanted and stay only part of the time with their husbands. Anne Parfait, the wife of Nicolas de Baugy,⁵ the French resident to the Imperial Court from 1601 to 1623, returned to France several times,

⁴ Semantic analyses have been conducted only in a part of this corpus. These 1500 letters were written to the king or secretary of state by the French resident in the Holy Roman Empire between 1617 and 1624.

⁵ We do not know much about the private life of French agents like Nicolas de Baugy whose lifetime presents to historians three major issues: low-ranking nobility, minor political positions (residents and not ambassadors) and a long-time dedication to abroad diplomatic duties (twenty-two years at

mostly in order to give birth,⁶ while her husband continued at the Imperial Court. The wife of Jean Hotman, the French resident to the Protestant Union from 1609 to 1614,⁷ joined her husband in April 1611, two years after his arrival in Düsseldorf.⁸ The few references to ambassador's wives in their husband's letters do not allow us to determine whether a case is an exception or the common situation, but clearly reveal a real separation between private and diplomatic life. As long as both did not interfere with each other, the diplomatic agents had no reason to write about private matters.⁹

These examples tend, however, to record some diplomatic uselessness by the ambassador's wife in the accomplishment of her husband's duties.¹⁰¹¹ But, if wives belonged to the private sphere, the

the Imperial court, four years at the Bruxelles court, four years in the Dutch Republic). Moreover, only a few personal papers have been preserved and are mostly about financial matters (Laval, Archives départementales de la Mayenne, 6J24). Consequently, we know little about Anne Parfait other than she was the daughter of Guillaume Parfait, controller at the king's house, and gave to Nicolas de Baugy four children (Bibliothèque nationale de France, Chérin 18, "Baugy").

⁶ Unfortunately we do not know the length of her absences. Baugy mentions only the departures of his wife, often in order to ask for permission (cf. *Infra*).

⁷ Because of his work, *L'ambassadeur*, Jean Hotman is better known than many other French agents in the Holy Roman Empire. Nevertheless, most of the historical and biographical studies focus on his literary work more than his diplomatic activity. See, for example, Mona Garloff: *Irenik, Gelehrsamkeit und Politik: Jean Hotman und der europäische Religionskonflikt um 1600*. Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2014, which is mostly dedicated to Hotman's irenic attitude and literary production.

⁸ Louis XIII: Passport to Mme Hotman, Fontainebleau, 18 April 1611. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, Français [fr.]4030, fol. 4.

⁹ As soon as letters became less official, references to women increase. Most of them can indeed be found in private letters between agents or between an agent and a foreign, but friendly, minister. Georg-Michel von Lingelsheim, Palatine minister and friend of Étienne de Sainte-Catherine, often ended his letters with the following: "Ma femme et enfans vous baisent les mains" (Georg-Michel von Lingelsheim: Letter to Étienne de Sainte-Catherine, Heidelberg, 4 May 1620. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 4122, fol. 3).

¹⁰ Camille Desenclos: *Les mots du pouvoir: la communication politique de la France dans le Saint-Empire au début de la guerre de Trente Ans (1617-1624)*., PhD diss., École nationale des chartes/Université Paris-Sorbonne, 2014, t. 1, pp. 114–115.

¹¹ While Lingelsheim often sends Sainte-Catherine his wife's regards, there are never any reciprocal comments from Sainte-Catherine. The French resident himself never speaks about a wife or children, unlike other agents whose letters were punctuated by familial evocations.

boundary between domestic and diplomatic life seems to indicate some porosity. Jean Hotman highlighted in his work *L'ambassadeur* (1603), the importance of a diplomatic agent taking his wife abroad with him, so that she could watch over his household and thus avoid any behaviour amongst the domestic staff which might cause prejudice to the king's credit/reputation:

Pour revenir à ses domestiques, nostre ambassadeur ne pouvant tousjours avoir l'oeil sur eux, tant pour sa dignité que pour les occupations de sa charge, le meilleur sera, s'il peut, mener sa femme avec luy, l'oeil de laquelle arrestera sans doute infinies débauches de ses gens et de desordre en sa maison.¹²

Hotman, however, did not mention any role for the ambassador's wife regarding watching the behaviour of the diplomatic staff.

Crossover between the private and diplomatic spheres nevertheless punctuated the agents' letters. Baugy, for example, applied in September 1619,¹³ and again in December 1620¹⁴ for leave in order to escort his pregnant wife to Paris and protect her from the dangers of traveling such a distance. As a diplomatic agent could not leave his diplomatic duties without permission from his king, Baugy had to mention his private life in his diplomatic letters. Used here as an argument in the request, the ambassador's wife could also be used as justification in order to cover a fault. In September 1619, Jean Péricard,

French resident to the Archdukes of Flanders (1616-1624),¹⁵ left Bruxelles, without asking or even warning the king or the secretary of state that a burgher's rebellion in Bruxelles might cause him danger. If Péricard did not leave the Spanish Netherlands, he did not stay close to the Archdukes and failed in his representative duty. Péricard immediately blamed his wife, rather than trying to justify himself:

Elles, ma femme et ma fille qui est grosse, et Madame de Cheneveille qui est par deçà pour affaires, ne m'ayent emmené à Villeworde deux lieues de cette ville, où la pluspart des officiers et principales familles s'estoyent retirez, je me laissay emporter à la foyblesse des femmes qui ne prevoient seureté qu'en mon assistance [...] L'alarme neantmoins ne pouvoyt

¹² Jean Hotman: *L'ambassadeur*. [Paris]: n.d., 1603, pp. 32–33.

¹³ Nicolas de Baugy: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Francfort, 6 September 1619. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 15929, fol. 373.

¹⁴ Nicolas de Baugy: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Vienna, 12 December 1620. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 15930, fol. 512.

¹⁵ Camille Desenclos, *Les mots du pouvoir*, t. 1, p. 116–118.

estre que tres grande comme il a esté en verité et pouvoyt esmouvoir quelque inconvenient qu'il a esté bon d'éviter puisque nul devoir ne nous obligeoit d'y participer.¹⁶

In both Baugy and Péricard's correspondence, the women's mentions meet the diplomatic needs (leave, justification and so on). Women might be outside of the diplomatic sphere but could modify its course either by their own existence or, sometimes, by a more direct interference in diplomatic life.

In July 1617, Péricard sent his wife to Paris in order to put down the numerous rumours circulating against him.¹⁷ For several weeks prior to this, he faced up to insinuations made by César de Bourbon, duke of Vendôme (1594-1665)¹⁸ and to direct accusations made by Leonora Galigai (1568-1617),¹⁹ Concino Concini's wife, who both reported close contacts between the French agent and Concini.²⁰ Péricard's wife, Madeleine Galmet,²¹ had to prove her husband's fidelity to the French king. Insofar as Péricard only mentioned his wife's journey to the French court, we cannot determine her exact participation in her husband's defence: she could have been only carrying Péricard's letters or explaining in detail her husband's actions to the king. The latter hypothesis would imply the exchange of political information between Péricard and his wife and her participation in, or at least close

¹⁶ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 25 September 1619. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16132, fol. 228.

¹⁷ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 7 July 1617. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16131, fol. 98.

¹⁸ Jean Péricard: Letter to Nicolas de Neufville, seigneur de Villeroy, Bruxelles, 24 May 1617. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16131, fol. 52.

¹⁹ Ernest de Bouteiller and Eugène Hèppe: *Correspondance politique adressée au magistrat de Strasbourg par ses agents à Metz (1594–1683)*. Paris: Berger-Levrault, 1882, pp. 157.

²⁰ The dazzling rise of Concino Concini, Marie de Medici's favourite, crystallized hatred from the nobility, then from the whole kingdom. On April 24th, 1617, Concini was killed while being arrested and Marie de Medici excluded from the royal government: Louis Batiffol: "Le coup d'État du 24 avril 1617", in: *Revue historique* 95 (1907), pp. 292–308; Hélène Duccini: *Concini : grandeur et misère du favori de Marie de Médicis*. Paris: A. Michel, 1991.

²¹ As for Anne Parfait, we know little about Marie Galmet, a daughter of a president of Orléans's *bureau des finances*. She had only one child with Péricard, a daughter who married Baron Poilley. See, Madeleine Galmet: Testament, Paris, 16 January 1626. Paris, Archives Nationales, ET/CV/267.

observation of the diplomatic practice. Péricard sent her to the French court again in May 1619,²² and then, in April 1620,²³ in order to complain, at both times, about the late payment of Péricard's wages and to request a rise, as life at the Bruxelles court would be more expensive than everywhere else in the Holy Roman Empire.²⁴

Péricard was, however, the only French agent in the Holy Roman Empire who involved his wife outside of the domestic sphere. The reception given to his wife in Paris suggests that this involvement, whose frequency, in Péricard's case, was made easier by the geographical proximity of Bruxelles,²⁵ was neither exceptional nor misplaced. Above all, Madeleine Galmet's missions were never directly bound up in diplomatic practice but to the domestic or private sphere. Diplomatic matters such as passing on sensitive information or collecting new orders belonged to the secretary of the embassy. But, if domestic and diplomatic matters seemed distinct because Galmet's missions concerned Péricard as a private individual rather than a diplomat, they did, in fact, influence his diplomatic future and actions. The accusations, which he had to face up to after Concini's death, could have led to his dismissal.²⁶

THE AMBASSADOR'S WIFE AS A DIPLOMATIC EXTENSION OF HER HUSBAND

²² Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 8 May 1619. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16132, fol. 133.

²³ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 3 April 1620. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16132, fol. 353.

²⁴ This kind of claim is recurrent in diplomatic letters. A diplomatic charge rarely led to fortune but required, on the contrary, being independently wealthy in order to be able to assume the diplomatic expenses. In Péricard's case nevertheless, the claims were justified. The wages for French agents in the Holy Roman Empire were much lower. Péricard received only 12000 *livres* (each year), while the French ambassador to the Papal court received 42000 *livres* and the French ambassadors in Spain, England and Venezia 18000 *livres* (Camille Desenclos: *Les mots du pouvoir*, t. 1, p. 127–129).

²⁵ Paris could be reached from Bruxelles in a few days and despite the outbreak of the Thirty Years War, roads remained safe, as the armies were fighting further east.

²⁶ In fact, they already caused some disgrace: Péricard had been demoted from ambassador to resident. The personal nature of this sanction is certain: Péricard attributed this demotion as a sanction for his supposed links with Concini (Jean Péricard: Letter to Nicolas de Neufville, seigneur de Villeroy, Bruxelles, 27 April 1617. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16125, fol. 317). Péricard's successor, Nicolas de Baugy, would be sent as ambassador.

In the early modern period, private and public spheres could not be strictly separated. By helping her husband in personal matters as discussed above, the ambassador's wife experienced a porosity between the private and public. Court life led her further in to a middle path. As she managed the household, it fell to her, at her husband's side, to welcome the French noblemen, who travelled through Bruxelles,²⁷ as well as every extraordinary French ambassador, for whom Péricard had to organise grand events and banquets at their arrival in order to enhance the importance of their diplomatic mission and the French king's reputation.²⁸ Thus, when Gaspard III de Coligny, duke of Chastillon (1584-1646), broke his journey to The Hague at Bruxelles, Madeleine Galmet kept him company:

Monsieur de Chastillon a passé en cette ville depuis six jours allant en Holande et m'ayant envoyé prier par l'un des sieurs de luy envoyer ung carrosse pour me venir veoyr, je le feuz à l'instant trouver en son hostellerye, luy fey offre de mon logis avec tout l'honneur que je sçay estre deu à sa qualité et à son merite, mais estant pressé de passer il ne le voulut accepter et n'a sejourné icy qu'une apres-disnée et n'a faict aulcune visite que de nous, ayant pris la peine de nous venir veoyr peu apres dans mon carrosse que je luy envoyay. Il passa le reste du jour avec ma femme et la baronne de Poilley, ma fille, et moy jusques à sept heures du soir que la barque d'Anvers partoit.²⁹

If the ambassador's wife performed here a social function, her mention in Péricard's letter takes on a diplomatic stance. This account is anything but anecdotal as is shown by the lengthy account the letter: Péricard wanted to testify that he had taken care, according to his duties, of this high-ranking French nobleman. His wife's behaviour, thus, gained a diplomatic element, such as at a dinner or in a coach, which allowed him to both accomplish his duties and to show the quality of his work to the secretary of state.

Making use of his wife in the diplomatic sphere was not only evidenced by internal French business, but also over-spilled into the European scene. Péricard's wife took part in the main events of the

²⁷ Every French nobleman had to greet the French ambassador in Bruxelles as representative of the king, so that the monarchy can keep watch and control the French nobility, even abroad.

²⁸ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 11 May 1619. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16132, fol. 135.

²⁹ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 7 December 1617. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16131, fol. 451.

Bruxelles court³⁰ as she attended the public audiences of the Infanta Isabella.³¹ Péricard placed himself and his family, inside the Court, unlike Baugy who never wrote about such interactions by either his wife or himself. If the Bruxelles court outshone by its splendour the Imperial court, Baugy's behaviour was caused by a latent hostility between the house of Habsburg and the French king which prevented him to gain any attention from the Imperial counsellors. However, Baugy did not live out of the Imperial Court but in its margins, reaching the center of the Court life only when necessary. But while Baugy did not write about his participation to the Court life, why did Péricard mention the participation of his wife and daughter to Court events? Once again, the ambassador's wife served as proof. As the king's representative, the ambassador enjoyed a high position at Court, which had to be maintained at all costs. The ambassador's wife, as an extension of her husband's person, demanded the same consideration at Court as that afforded him. Invitations to ballets, comedies, and her place at Court testified to the quality of the ambassador's integration inside the Bruxelles Court, the fulfillment of his diplomatic duties and the respect of a foreign sovereign for the king's status and reputation through the ambassador and his wife's persons.³²

Despite the rare references, the diplomatic function of the ambassador's wife was not insignificant. In May 1622, the *chapín* (a Spanish overshoe) of Péricard's wife was thrown from a window by another lady of the Court during a public audience with the Infanta. Péricard immediately considered himself, and, by extension the king, as offended. This case is everything but anecdotal. Péricard wrote a long and fully detailed letter about this event,³³ then another one, five days later, about its consequences.³⁴ No details were forgotten by the French resident: the immediate displeasure of the

³⁰ In February 1620, Péricard related that his wife and daughter, like several other women of the court, had taken part in the comedy and ballet which was organised by the Infanta (Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 29 February 1620. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16132, fol. 333).

³¹ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 12 May 1622. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 17891, fol. 389.

³² “Demain se jouera et dansera la comédie et le ballet des dames du palais dont ma femme et la baronne de Poilley ma fille sont prises de la part de l'Infante” (Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 29 February 1620. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16132, fol. 333).

³³ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 12 May 1622. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 17891, fol. 389.

³⁴ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 15 May 1622. Paris,

Infanta, her promise of punishment, her gift of a new overshoe to Péricard's wife. The story can be followed almost hour by hour. In fact, Péricard's diplomatic status prevented the incident from being regarded as a simple quarrel between two women. His status turned any insult, even a personal one, into an insult against the French king. Péricard did not develop in his letter the origins and reasons of this quarrel, they did not matter, only the event itself and its outcomes did. Péricard had to report it before others informed the French king and turned it into a major diplomatic incident. The quick management by the Infanta through a Council meeting, corroborates the potential diplomatic extent of this quarrel. Péricard himself acknowledged that the Infanta's response was the result of "le respect du roi en ma personne [qui] luy estoit si cher".³⁵ If Péricard's wife indirectly took advantage of her husband's diplomatic protection despite not fulfilling a representative function, its transposition into action inserted her in to the diplomatic field and made her a passive actor, nay a subject of attention within the diplomatic ceremonial. Insofar as the ambassador's wife depended on her husband's person, she took part, by her own presence at court, in the defence of her king's glory and could, therefore, be considered as a diplomatic and not only a social extension of her husband's person.

In June 1621, as Baugy related in one of his letters,³⁶ the new nuncio, Carlo Caraffa (1584-1644)³⁷ arrived in Vienna. As a new ambassador in a foreign Court, he should be visited by each other foreign representative. Through his behaviour and the sequence of his visits to the foreign agents, the new nuncio had to express the nature of the relationship between the Pope and the other European sovereigns as well as their places within the European hierarchy. When Caraffa arrived in Vienna, Baugy visited him. The nuncio, however, did not pay a return visit, although he asked twice to visit Baugy's wife, who was constrained by her husband to decline and exposed her political and diplomatic dependence on her husband. Baugy expressed clearly the reasons of his refusal in a letter to the French secretary of state. The rules of European diplomacy forced the nuncio to visit him and not his wife. Any other process would question the French king's status and reputation. The visit which the nuncio had paid to the Spanish ambassador made the case even more complex, as the

Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 17891, fol. 390v.

³⁵ Ibidem.

³⁶ Nicolas de Baugy: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux. Vienna, 9 June 1621. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 15931, fol. 271.

³⁷ Johannes Paul Anthieny: *Der päbstliche Nuntius Carl Caraffa: ein Beitrag zur Geschichte der Deissigjährigen Kriegen*. Berlin: Nietack, 1869.

relationship between the French and the Spanish diplomacies was rather tense, especially at the Imperial court.³⁸ By not visiting the French resident, the nuncio would grant the Spanish ambassador precedence over the French and demonstrated the Pope's preference for the Spanish king. As the Papacy did not want to formally break with the French, the nuncio seized on the pretext of a visit to the French resident's wife. Baugy was fully aware that the nuncio did not really wish to visit his wife but was using it in order to visit him without expressing it officially. In this way, Baugy's wife became a diplomatic tool, a way to flatter the Spanish diplomacy by according them precedence, without breaking with the French. Baugy himself called it a pretext: "pour me donner quelque contentement, il s'estoit offert de venir ceans souz pretexte de visiter ma femme et qu'aprez il m'eust aussy veu non comme ministre du roy mais comme son amy et personne privé".³⁹ Whatever Baugy's displeasure, the nuncio would not reconsider and visit him. In return, Baugy refused, from that point, to interact with him.

Beyond the latent hostility between the French and Spanish kings, this quarrel points, once again, to the diplomatic function of the ambassador's wife as conceived by the diplomatic agents themselves: she belonged to the private sphere – through her, the nuncio would have visited Baugy as a 'private person' – but was close enough to the diplomatic sphere to intervene and assume a passive function when needed to serve the diplomatic interests of her sovereign or fill in for her husband. Like Baugy's wife, women did not personally intervene in the diplomatic sphere; they were used, sometimes even manipulated, used by male agents without any real involvement on their part. It is, however, tricky to estimate the exact rate of their interaction in the diplomatic field: did they remain only as passive actresses through their presence at Court or had they to represent and defend more actively, their king? On the account of her relations with many Court ladies, Madeleine Galmet could be employed to collect additional information. Such a use was never acknowledged in her husband's letters; but

³⁸ Quarrels over precedence between the French and Spanish kings had underlain public ceremonies since the sixteenth century. As the French king presented himself as the first of the Christian kings and the "elder son of the Catholic Church", he claimed precedence over the other European sovereigns. Since the mid-sixteenth century however, Philipp II of Spain questioned the French king's place as he actively would defend more actively the Catholic faith. Furthermore, precedence over the French resident would be granted to the Spanish ambassador by the Emperor, as member of the same house of Habsburg and would alter the French King's reputation: Alain Tallon: *L'Europe au XVIe siècle: États et relations internationales*. Paris: Presses universitaires de France, 2010, pp. 130–131.

³⁹ Nicolas de Baugy: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux. Vienna, 9 June 1621. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 15931, fol. 271.

perhaps the ambassador protected his wife by only noting her actions anonymously. Neither hypotheses can be proved nor denied. Several visits to Madeleine Galmet certainly turned into diplomatic meetings, like in June 1619 that of the Countess of Bucquoy whose husband led the Imperial armies. During this visit, Péricard took the opportunity to reaffirm the French king's desire to see the Bohemian troubles settled and to collect new information on the Imperial situation.⁴⁰ However, from this point, the discussion was led by Péricard. Madeleine Galmet appeared to have been put aside as soon as the discussion became diplomatic.

WHEN PRIVATE BECOMES PUBLIC: THE QUEEN

The ambivalence of the women's diplomatic place, private and public, and their role, passive and/or active, was even bigger for princesses and queens. Although they were undoubtedly public persons, they were, almost, always referenced for what should belong to the private sphere:⁴¹ birth, marriage, pregnancy, illness, death. These private events were, in fact, the most public in Europe according to their influence on European diplomatic balance, especially in regard to pregnancies which would make a succession easier. Through their "actions", queens took an equal part in the future of a state and its foreign policy. Each event was thus fully related by ambassadors. They did not present, however, the princesses or queens as women but only as indirect, almost involuntary, actresses of European politic and diplomatic life. When Zsuzsanna Karolyi, Bethlen Gabor's wife, died in 1622, Baugy related and analysed immediately the consequences of this opportune death: it could open the way to a remarriage between Bethlen Gabor, prince of Transylvania (1613-1629) and the contested king of Hungary (1620-1621), and the daughter of the duke von Jägerndorf, one of the leaders of the Protestant Union, giving rise to discontent amongst the Hungarians who seemed to be wearied by their alliance with the Palatine faction.⁴²

The female condition, however, prevented queens from taking an official part in the diplomatic game.

⁴⁰ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 11 June 1619. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 15931, fol. 271.

⁴¹ Queens were both subjects and sovereigns. Their marriages created a subjection to their royal husbands but transferred to them also a royal status which conferred to each of their actions a political value (Fanny Cosandey: *La reine de France: symbole et pouvoir XVe–XVIIIe siècles*. Paris: Gallimard, 2000, pp. 114–116).

⁴² Nicolas de Baugy: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Vienna, 1st June 1622. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 15932, fol. 154.

They had to wait for an upgrade of their political status, such as regent or governor, in order to be considered no more as a woman but as a sovereign. They integrated as such fully into the diplomatic field and were mentioned in the same way as male sovereigns: about negotiations, audiences, foreign policy, etc. thus, in the 1610s, Isabella was mentioned in Péricard's letters, mainly concerning Court matters⁴³ or, as she co-governed with Archduke Albert⁴⁴, about joint audiences. During Albert's illness in 1619, the rate of Court and diplomatic references tended to balance out: the Infanta had to undertake alone the audiences and became thus a full diplomatic actor. After Albert's death, this rate was totally reversed. The references to Court life disappeared or mingled with the diplomatic references. In the same audience, the Infanta would discuss Court, family and diplomacy:

Selon la coustume et les ceremonies ordinaires de cette Cour, je donnay hier à l'Infante les bonnes Pasques de la Nativité de Nostre Seigneur et luy repetay en peu de paroles nostre attente d'une finale et tres expresse ordonnance du roy d'Espagne pour l'execution du traicté de Madrid dont je ne l'importunoy point davantage sçachant sa bonne et sincere intention. Et sur ce que je luy diz de bonne sorte et d'une façon complaisante qu'elle tenoyt l'équilibre de l'amitié et bonne intelligence entre les deux couronnes et que l'on s'en prendroyt à elle si ce fascheux affaire la traversoyt, je ne vous sçauroy dignement représenter les nouvelles assurances qu'elle m'a donné que tout s'acheveroyt au contentement du roy esperant que le courrier que Sa Majesté a despeché en Espagne le rapportera tout entiere. Elle s'est informée à l'accoustumée de la santé de Sa Majesté, estant tres aise de l'arrivée de la royne à Paris à qui elle a envoyé ce jour d'huy deux muletz chargez de diverses quaiesses pleines de presens.⁴⁵

The disappearance of gender-related references to female sovereigns can be observed both in the ambassadors' and the queens' letters. First, no differences between a letter written by a king or by a

⁴³ "Je ne doibz obmettre les honnestes paroles que l'Infante me dict encor en ma derniere audience de l'estime qu'elle faisoit de la boeste que le roy luy a envoyé, laquelle elle me monstra pendue et attachée à l'endroict de son cueur avec resolution de la porter jusques à la fin de sa vie. Elle trouve la royne trop grasse en son portraict et les yeux trop grans et desereroit bien en avoir ung vrayment ressemblant et s'il plaisoit à Sa Majesté envoyer celui du roy et le sien de leur grandeur" (Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 13 May 1618. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16131, fol. 312).

⁴⁴ Camille Desenclos, *Les mots du pouvoir*, t. 1, p. 67–73.

⁴⁵ Jean Péricard: Letter to Pierre Brulart, viscount Puisieux, Bruxelles, 27 December 1621. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 16134, fol. 248.

female governor can be noticed in its form. Both letters would have been written by men: each diplomatic letter was prepared by the secretary of state and written by a clerk. The signature only was appended by the king or the regent, when it was not counterfeited by a qualified secretary. Anytime, the writing process remained the same. Secondly, while governing, women were considered, and considered themselves, as sovereign, not as women. In the Spanish Netherlands, the Infanta kept the sovereignty over the Spanish Netherlands, even after Archduke Albert's death in 1621, despite a stronger Spanish tutelage. In Marie de Medici's case, the regency's principles prevented an absolute takeover: the male or female regent was the custodian of the kingdom until the king's majority—the king remained the true sovereign. Therefore, a triple diplomatic correspondence was set up: the diplomatic agents wrote, as usual, their weekly reports to the secretary of state but had to split their correspondence to the royal power. As the monarch and the decision-making power were momentarily split because of the regency, a doubling of royal correspondence, between the king and the regent, had to be established in order to facilitate the circulation of information.⁴⁶ However, this doubling was not always the rule. The diplomatic agents wrote only to the Queen Mother, and to the secretary of state. As Marie de Medici ensured French internal and foreign policy, she imposed herself as the sovereign in the diplomatic correspondence and revealed the nebulous nature of power during a regency:⁴⁷ functions were never institutionalised and depended on the political structure which had been decided by the regent. Royal correspondence, however, did not work in the same way. It could be signed either by the regent or by the king. Marie de Medici ensured, for example, all the correspondence with agents such as Jean Hotman,⁴⁸ resident to the Protestant Union (1609-1614),⁴⁹

⁴⁶ When Catherine de Medici's regency was established, an arrangement had defined this double correspondence: any letter to the king should go with a letter to the Queen Mother (Matthieu Gellard: *Une reine épistolaire: lettres et pouvoir au temps de Catherine de Médicis*. Paris: Garnier, 2014, p. 108).

⁴⁷ Fanny Cosandey: *La reine de France*, p. 318.

⁴⁸ Jean Hotman: *Letters from the French Court, 1603–1619*. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 4030.

⁴⁹ This direct correspondence with Hotman appears to be related to his mission in the Jülich-crisis. Marie de Medici wanted more probably to be perfectly informed about the negotiations between both claimed heirs, than to control the whole French Imperial policy herself. However, this cannot be fully confirmed. Only three French agents had been permanently sent to the Holy Roman Empire during her regency: Jean Hotman (Protestant Union: 1609–1614), Étienne de Sainte-Catherine (Palatine Court: 1612–1620) and Nicolas de Baugy (Imperial Court: 1601–1623). The diplomatic papers of Étienne de Sainte-Catherine contain only letters from the secretary of state, not from the regent or the king (Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 4121), and the

or Samuel Spifame, seigneur de Bisseaux, ambassador to the King of England (1610-1624),⁵⁰ but she wrote only a few letters to François Savary de Brèves, ambassador in Rome (1607-1614).⁵¹ The letters to Brèves talked merely about secondary business like internal noble cases, i.e. recommendation for noblemen, support for a request of marital exemption, and so on.⁵² This epistolary difference seems to have been caused by the country in which the embassy resided. Unfortunately, the whole royal correspondence has not been preserved for that time, as this was incumbent on the recipients, in this case, the agents. The relationship with Rome was probably the most ceremonious but was also rather peaceful at that time: the secretary of state alone could manage the cases and write official letters on behalf of the king. For states like the Kingdom of England or the Holy Roman Empire, where the French diplomacy was involved in the peace negotiations about the Jülich Succession (1609-1614)⁵³, Marie de Medici needed to arrange for herself information and orders. Her letters thus expressed both diplomatic and ceremonial needs.

When the king's majority was proclaimed in 1614, the epistolary ratio changed: each letter to the Queen Mother now went with a letter to the king. The king, moreover, became the primary recipient. When letters were sent to the Queen Mother at the same time, they referred to the letter to the king.⁵⁴ Even the length of the letters changed: the letters to the Queen Mother barely exceeded one page, whereas those to the king spread over several pages. The first letters however were not gutted. The diplomatic agents outlined, even completed the letter to the king by their letter to the Queen

diplomatic papers of Nicolas de Baugy appear to be lost.

⁵⁰ Samuel Spifame, sieur de Bisseaux: Letters to and from the French Court, 1611–1612. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 15986.

⁵¹ François Savary de Brèves: Letters from the French Court, 1612. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 3792.

⁵² Marie de Medici: Letter to François Savary de Brèves, Fontainebleau, 13 June 1612. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 3792, fol. 44.

⁵³ In 1609, Johann Wilhelm, duke of Jülich-Cleves-Berg died and his only son, from a morganatic marriage, was not entitled to succeed him. Two of his nephews claimed for his titles and privileges: Albert Frederik, elector of Brandenburg, and Philipp Ludwig, duke of Palatinate-Neuburg whose son converted to catholicism in 1613. In November 1614, the conflict is ended through a French-English mediation and the treaty of Xanten signed. See Alison Deborah Anderson: *On the verge of war: International Relations and the Jülich-Kleve Succession Crises (1609-1614)*. Boston: Humanities Press, 1999.

⁵⁴ “Madame, je rends compte au roy comme il a pleu à Vostre Majesté me commander de toutes les occurrences de ceste cour” (François Jouvenel des Ursins: Letter to Marie de Medici, Rom, 23 December 1614. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 18009, fol. 350).

Mother⁵⁵. The advantages of such a double correspondence nevertheless have to be questioned: the Queen Mother still sat in the Council; she read the letters to the king as well and was involved in answering. This double correspondence contributed towards an acknowledgement of the continuity of Marie de Medici's government⁵⁶ but with a new status. Because of the king's majority, Marie de Medici had to give up her role as regent, and had lost her overwhelming power.⁵⁷ Therefore, letters had to be written by and to the king. However, by appointing his mother as head of the Council, the king still entrusted her with royal authority and allowed her, indirectly, to maintain all her diplomatic correspondence, although under his formal control.

After the "Coup de Majesté" in April 1617⁵⁸, Marie de Medici lost all power and came back to the social and familial sphere. Her position, as expressed in the diplomatic correspondence, was now the same as that of Anne of Austria (1601-1666), the young wife of Louis XIII (1610-1643). In January 1620, three letters were sent to Emperor Ferdinand II (1619-1637): one from the king,⁵⁹ one from the queen,⁶⁰ and finally another one from the Queen Mother.⁶¹ In this epistolary exchange, both queens

⁵⁵ "J'ajousteray seulement qu'ayans tous lesdits princes monsté de croire que accomplissant avec Monsieur le duc de Bavières les mesmes offices que j'ay passé avec eux, cela ayderoit grandement à l'effet pour lequel Voz Majestez m'ont renvoyé en Allemagne pour la grande creance qu'il a parmy les catoliques, je me destourne de mon chemin exprez pour l'aller trouver à Munich et luy declarer les bonnes proceddures et intentions de Voz Majestez pour l'affermissement de la tranquillité publique et specialement dans le Saint Empire" (Nicolas de Baugy: Letter to Marie de Medici, Augsburg, 23 January 1615. Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, fr. 15927, fol. 18).

⁵⁶ Matthieu Gellard's analyse can be used again for Marie de Medici's case: "La présence dans les lettres de Catherine de Médicis de renvois à celles du roi a pour vocation de légitimer son écriture en l'articulant à celle du souverain – la lettre du roi est en effet la plus importante, celle qui ne peut disparaître tandis que celle de la reine mère n'existe que tant qu'elle-même se maintient au pouvoir [...] La présence, dans les lettres du roi, de renvois à celles de sa mère légitime à son tour l'existence de ces dernières tout en leur laissant une place pour exister puisque la lettre royale ne dit pas tout" (Matthieu Gellard: *Une reine épistolaire*, p. 116).

⁵⁷ Fanny Cosandey: *La reine de France*, p. 319.

⁵⁸ On April 24th, 1617, Concino Concini, Marie de Medici's favorite, was arrested and killed while Marie de Medici was exiled in Blois.

⁵⁹ Louis XIII: Letter to Ferdinand II, Paris, 10 January 1620. Vienna, Österreichisches Staatsarchiv, Haus-, Hof- und Staatsarchiv, Frankreich, Hofkorrespondenz 3.

⁶⁰ Anne of Austria: Letter to Ferdinand II, Paris, 12 January 1620. Vienna, Österreichisches Staatsarchiv, Haus-, Hof- und Staatsarchiv, Frankreich, Hofkorrespondenz 3.

⁶¹ Marie de Medici: Letter to Ferdinand II, Angers, 22 January 1620. Vienna, Österreichisches

took no initiative; their letters followed the king's by a couple of days. As a result of her past power, the content of Marie de Medici's letter was slightly more diplomatic, whereas Anne of Austria's letter only referred to the king's letter for the diplomatic matter (the answer made to the extraordinary Imperial ambassador, Wratislaw count of Furstenberg (1584-1631)),⁶² and ensured the Emperor of her affection in a familial way.⁶³ Marie de Medici's letter detailed the content of the decision and expressed her satisfaction with it:

Nous avons reçu la lettre que nous a apporté de vostre part un gentilhomme qu'a despesché vers nous le comte de Firstemberg que vous avez envoyé ambassadeur en France et avons esté fort contente de ce que le roy nostre tres honnoré sieur et filz s'est porté à vous promettre le secours que l'estat present des affaires de l'Empire desiroit de luy. Nostre absence pour lors nous a empeschée de contribuer à la resolution qui en a esté promptement prise, mais nous apporterons tout ce qui nous sera possible pour en avancer l'effect d'aussy bon cœur que nous prions Dieu vous garder longues années pour la conservation du Saint Empire.⁶⁴

But if Marie de Medici's letter talked more about the French foreign policy, the Queen Mother did not credit herself with the decision of rescuing the Emperor. She only, in a polite way, regretted not having initiated this decision and ensured the Emperor she would spend her time in turning the decision into reality. That however, did not indicate any new diplomatic activity from the Queen Mother but was caused by epistolary politeness and European official benevolence between the major European sovereigns. From then on, Marie de Medici's letters have no intrinsic value. While they

Staatsarchiv, Haus-, Hof- und Staatsarchiv, Frankreich, Hofkorrespondenz 3.

⁶² Camille Desenclos: *Les mots du pouvoir*, t. 1, p. 443–450.

⁶³ “Nous remettant entierement à ce que le roy nostre tres honnoré seigneur et espoux escrit à Vostre Majesté et aux responces qu'il a faictes au sieur comte de Fustemberg vostre ambassadeur, nous l'avons seulement prié de vous asseurer de nostre affection en vostre endroict et du contentement que nous avons reçu d'apprendre des nouvelles de la santé de Vostre Majesté, desirant passionnement qu'elle nous tienne en ses bonnes graces et qu'elle croye de trouver tousjours en nous les effectz de la bienveillance à laquelle nous sommes obligez par l'estroite liaison de sang et d'amitié que nous avons avec Vostre Majesté” (Anne of Austria: Letter to Ferdinand II, Paris, 12 January 1620. Vienna, Österreichisches Staatsarchiv, Haus-, Hof- und Staatsarchiv, Frankreich, Hofkorrespondenz 3).

⁶⁴ Marie de Medici: Letter to Ferdinand II, Angers, 22 January 1620. Vienna, Österreichisches Staatsarchiv, Haus-, Hof- und Staatsarchiv, Frankreich, Hofkorrespondenz 3.

were equal to king's letters when she was regent, they became again, like the letters from the queen, diplomatic tools which existed only in order to support royal decisions.

As queens, women were, in French diplomatic correspondence, deprived of any personal diplomatic status. They wrote on their own only about social or familial matters and were used as obliging relays for their son's or husband's decisions. In this regard, their way of designating the king was meaningful: "le roy nostre tres honnoré seigneur et espoux"⁶⁵ or "le roy mon fils"⁶⁶. The mention of kingship always came first. They did not possess on their own any power and remained the king's subjects. They benefitted, however, from the king's power in a passive but essential way: in defending the king's position in Europe. Women's letters tended to confirm the role which the ambassadors defined in their letters: a passive representative function in the European court society but with some useful diplomatic impact. In the weekly diplomatic letters and reports, women were so referenced only when they interfered with diplomatic practice. Diplomatic agents, however, wrote in their letters only what needed to be known by their masters, and the early modern French diplomacy in the Holy Roman Empire was, if not an exception, a particular case: because of the complex institutional and confessional structure of the Empire and the specific issues of Bruxelles and Vienna Courts (in the context of a remaining hostility with the house of Habsburg), the daily diplomatic practice did not offer the same patterns as in Rome or even Madrid. The status, the household and even the diplomatic activity were not as developed and so were the contribution of the ambassador's wife. It matched, albeit simply, the purpose of the diplomatic activity in the Holy Roman Empire and inserted itself only on the daily level, not in the written sources as letters and reports were focused on information more than concrete practice.

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⁶⁵ Anne of Austria: Letter to Ferdinand II, Paris, 12 January 1620. Vienna, Österreichisches Staatsarchiv, Haus-, Hof- und Staatsarchiv, Frankreich, Hofkorrespondenz 3.

⁶⁶ Marie de Medici: Letter to Ferdinand II, Angers, 22 January 1620. Vienna, Österreichisches Staatsarchiv, Haus-, Hof- und Staatsarchiv, Frankreich, Hofkorrespondenz 3.

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